

The ClickUp Freelancer CRM

Complete Setup Guide — Go from Scattered to Systemized in One Afternoon

Most freelancers track clients in their head, a messy spreadsheet, or not at all. This guide walks you through building a complete CRM inside ClickUp that handles your pipeline, active projects, finances, and recurring operations. Total setup time: 2-3 hours. Time saved: 5-10 hours per week, permanently.

What you need: A ClickUp account (free tier works for this). Everything below uses native ClickUp features — no integrations required for the base setup.

SPACE 1: CLIENT MANAGEMENT

This is your revenue engine. Every lead, active project, and past client lives here.

List 1: Pipeline

This is where leads enter and move through your sales process. Create a new List called "Pipeline" and add these custom fields:

Field Name	Field Type	Options / Notes
Company	Short Text	The business name
Contact Name	Short Text	Primary decision maker
Contact Email	Email	For quick access
Estimated Value	Currency (\$)	What the project is worth
Stage	Dropdown	Lead / Contacted / Discovery Call / Proposal Sent / Negotiation / Closed Won / Closed Lost
Source	Dropdown	Upwork / Referral / Cold Outreach / Inbound / Social Media / Other
Next Action	Short Text	e.g., "Send proposal by Friday"
Last Contact	Date	When you last reached out

Priority	Dropdown	Hot / Warm / Cold
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Statuses to configure:

Lead → Contacted → Discovery Call → Proposal Sent → Negotiation → Closed Won → Closed Lost

Pro tip: Set the default view to Board View grouped by "Stage." This gives you a visual Kanban pipeline. Drag cards between columns as deals progress.

List 2: Active Clients

Once a deal closes, it moves here. Create a new List called "Active Clients" with these custom fields:

Field Name	Field Type	Options / Notes
Project Name	Short Text	Descriptive name for the engagement
Company	Short Text	Linked to Pipeline entry
Project Value	Currency (\$)	Total contract value
Monthly Retainer	Currency (\$)	If applicable (leave blank for one-time)
Deadline	Date	Final delivery date
Status	Dropdown	Onboarding / In Progress / Review / Delivered / On Hold
Priority	Priority Field	Urgent / High / Normal / Low
Slack Channel	URL	Link to client Slack channel if applicable
Drive Folder	URL	Link to project Google Drive folder

Statuses to configure:

Onboarding → In Progress → Review → Delivered → On Hold

List 3: Completed

Past clients are future revenue. This list tracks post-project opportunities. Create "Completed" with these fields:

Field Name	Field Type	Options / Notes
Company	Short Text	Client business name
Project Summary	Long Text	One-liner of what you delivered
Final Value	Currency (\$)	What you actually invoiced
Completed Date	Date	When the project wrapped
Testimonial Received	Checkbox	Yes / No
Referral Asked	Checkbox	Yes / No
Upsell Offered	Checkbox	Yes / No
Upsell Notes	Long Text	What additional services could you offer?
Rating	Dropdown	A-Client / B-Client / C-Client (would you work with them again?)

Revenue hack: Sort this list by "Upsell Offered = No" once a month. Reach out to every past client you haven't pitched an upsell to. This alone can add 20-30% to your annual revenue.

SPACE 2: OPERATIONS

This space keeps your business running. Weekly tasks, monthly reviews, and content — all systematized.

List 1: Weekly Recurring Tasks

Create a list called "Weekly Recurring" and add these tasks (set each as a recurring task in ClickUp):

Task Name	Recurrence	Day	Notes
Pipeline Review	Weekly	Monday	Review every lead. Update stages. Follow up on stale deals.
Client Check-ins	Weekly	Tuesday	Send status update to every active client.
Content Batch	Weekly	Wednesday	Record / write / schedule 3-5 pieces of content.

Invoice Check	Weekly	Thursday	Review outstanding invoices. Send reminders.
Weekly Review	Weekly	Friday	Review wins, losses, metrics. Plan next week.
Upwork Profile Refresh	Weekly	Friday	Update portfolio, send 5 proposals.

List 2: Monthly Reviews

Create "Monthly Reviews" with these recurring tasks:

Task Name	Recurrence	Notes
Revenue Review	1st of month	Total invoiced, collected, outstanding. Compare to goal.
Client Satisfaction Check	1st of month	NPS-style check-in with every active client.
Tool Audit	15th of month	Review subscriptions. Cancel anything unused.
Upsell Outreach	15th of month	Contact 3 past clients with a new offer.
Goal Setting	Last day of month	Set revenue, client, and content goals for next month.

List 3: Content Calendar

Create "Content Calendar" with these custom fields:

Field Name	Field Type	Options / Notes
Platform	Dropdown	Instagram / LinkedIn / Twitter / YouTube / TikTok / Blog
Content Type	Dropdown	Hook Video / Carousel / Long-form / Story / Thread
Topic	Short Text	What the content is about
Publish Date	Date	When it goes live
Status	Dropdown	Idea / Drafting / Editing / Scheduled / Published
Link	URL	Link to published post
Performance	Number	Views / impressions after 48 hours

View tip: Set the default view to Calendar View grouped by "Publish Date." This gives you a visual content calendar. Switch to Board View grouped by "Status" when you need to see what's in progress.

SPACE 3: FINANCE

Know your numbers at a glance. No more digging through email to find who owes you what.

List 1: Invoices

Create "Invoices" with these custom fields:

Field Name	Field Type	Options / Notes
Invoice Number	Short Text	e.g., INV-2026-001
Client	Short Text	Company name
Amount	Currency (\$)	Invoice total
Status	Dropdown	Draft / Sent / Paid / Overdue / Cancelled
Issue Date	Date	When you sent it
Due Date	Date	Payment deadline (typically Net 15 or Net 30)
Paid Date	Date	When payment was received
Payment Method	Dropdown	Wise / PayPal / Stripe / Bank Transfer / Upwork
Invoice Link	URL	Link to PDF or invoicing tool

List 2: Expenses

Create "Expenses" with these custom fields:

Field Name	Field Type	Options / Notes
Tool / Service	Short Text	e.g., "n8n Cloud," "ClickUp," "Claude Pro"
Monthly Cost	Currency (\$)	What you pay per month
Annual Cost	Currency (\$)	If billed annually

Category	Dropdown	Software / Hosting / Marketing / Education / Contractor / Other
Billing Date	Date	When it renews
Essential	Checkbox	Would your business break without this?
Notes	Long Text	What do you use it for?

AUTOMATIONS TO SET UP

These 4 automations eliminate manual work and ensure nothing slips through the cracks. Set these up in ClickUp's Automations section (available on paid plans; free plans get limited automations).

Automation 1: Closed Won → Onboarding

Setting	Value
Trigger	When status changes to "Closed Won" in Pipeline list
Action 1	Create task from Template "Client Onboarding Checklist" in Active Clients list
Action 2	Assign to yourself
Action 3	Set due date to 3 days from trigger

Onboarding template should include:

- Send welcome email with project brief template
- Create shared Google Drive folder
- Schedule kickoff call
- Set up Slack channel (if applicable)
- Send contract and invoice
- Add to Active Clients with all custom fields

Automation 2: Due Date Reminder

Setting	Value
Trigger	When task due date is 1 day away (any list in Client Management)
Action	Send notification to Slack channel #tasks (or email if no Slack)

Automation 3: Task Completed → Review

Setting	Value
Trigger	When task status changes to "Delivered" in Active Clients
Action 1	Move task to Completed list
Action 2	Create subtask: "Request testimonial" (due in 3 days)
Action 3	Create subtask: "Ask for referral" (due in 7 days)
Action 4	Create subtask: "Pitch upsell" (due in 14 days)

Automation 4: Weekly Review Recurring

Setting	Value
Trigger	Every Friday at 3:00 PM
Action	Create task "Weekly Review" in Operations > Weekly Recurring

Weekly Review task description template:

```
## Weekly Review – [Week of DATE]
```

```
### Wins
```

```
-
```

```
### Pipeline Updates
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- New leads:
- Proposals sent:
- Deals closed:
- Pipeline value:

```
### Revenue
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- Invoiced this week: \$
- Collected this week: \$
- Outstanding: \$

```
### Next Week Priorities
```

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

DASHBOARD WIDGETS

Create a new Dashboard called "Freelance Command Center" and add these widgets:

Widget 1: Revenue This Month

Setting	Value
Widget Type	Calculation (Sum)
Source	Invoices list
Field	Amount
Filter	Status = "Paid" AND Paid Date = This Month

Widget 2: Pipeline Value

Setting	Value
Widget Type	Calculation (Sum)
Source	Pipeline list
Field	Estimated Value
Filter	Stage NOT IN (Closed Won, Closed Lost)

Widget 3: Tasks Overdue

Setting	Value
Widget Type	Task List
Source	All lists in all Spaces
Filter	Due Date is past AND Status is not "Complete"
Sort	Due Date (oldest first)

Widget 4: Tasks Completed This Week

Setting	Value
Widget Type	Bar Chart
Source	All lists in Client Management space
Filter	Status = "Complete" AND Date Closed = This Week
Group By	Day

Widget 5: Revenue by Client (Bonus)

Setting	Value
Widget Type	Pie Chart
Source	Invoices list
Field	Amount
Group By	Client
Filter	Status = "Paid" AND Paid Date = This Month

Time to set up: ~2-3 hours for everything. After that, you spend 15 minutes per day maintaining it and save 5-10 hours per week. This is the same system used to manage 15 staffing clients, a \$14,840 project pipeline, and maintain 100% Job Success on Upwork.

QUICK-START CHECKLIST

1. Create the 3 Spaces: Client Management, Operations, Finance
2. Create all Lists with the custom fields above
3. Set up the 4 Automations
4. Build the Dashboard with all 5 widgets
5. Import your existing leads into Pipeline
6. Move any current projects to Active Clients
7. Add your tools/subscriptions to Expenses
8. Set your first Weekly Review task for this Friday